

how do I find a good AP english language teacher

A good **AP English Language teacher or tutor** should do more than teach grammar or generic essay writing. They should be able to teach rhetorical analysis, synthesis, argumentation, source use, revision, and timed multiple-choice work—the central skills in the official AP Lang framework.

The best way to find one

Start with referrals from people who have seen the teacher’s work:

- Ask your school’s AP Lang teacher, English department chair, or guidance counselor for tutoring recommendations.
- Ask recent AP Lang students who improved significantly—not only students who were already strong writers.
- Check local parent/student groups and tutoring directories, but verify every recommendation yourself.
- For a complete online course rather than tutoring, search the College Board’s **AP Course Ledger**. It lists authorized schools and online AP course providers, although authorization does not guarantee that every individual teacher is excellent.

What to look for

A strong candidate should:

1. **Have recent AP Lang experience.**
They should understand the current exam, which is fully digital and includes 45 multiple-choice questions plus three essays: synthesis, rhetorical analysis, and argument.
2. **Use the official College Board rubric.**
Ask the teacher to score one of your essays and explain the score—not merely give you a grade.
3. **Give specific writing feedback.**
Useful feedback sounds like: “Your evidence is relevant, but this sentence does not explain how it proves your claim.” Comments such as “add detail” or “be more sophisticated” are not sufficient by themselves.
4. **Teach revision, not just formulas.**
A good teacher should help you improve thesis statements, evidence, commentary, line of reasoning, organization, and style. They should not rely exclusively on memorized templates.
5. **Use recent official material.**
College Board publishes released questions, scoring guidelines, student samples, and commentary. A qualified teacher should be comfortable using these resources.
6. **Create an individualized plan.**
The plan should begin with a diagnostic essay or practice set and identify your two or three biggest weaknesses.

Questions to ask before hiring

Ask these during an introductory call:

- “How recently have you taught or tutored AP English Language?”
- “How do you teach synthesis, rhetorical analysis, and argument differently?”
- “Could you show me how you would score one paragraph using the current rubric?”
- “How much writing will I complete between sessions?”
- “How quickly will I receive feedback?”
- “How do you teach commentary and line of reasoning?”
- “How do you prepare students for the digital Bluebook exam?”
- “Can you describe how you helped a student with weaknesses similar to mine?”
- “What would the first four weeks of tutoring look like?”

Use a trial lesson as an audition

Bring a timed essay you have already written. During the trial, ask the teacher to:

1. Score it using the AP rubric.
2. Identify your most important weakness.
3. Explain why that weakness matters.
4. Help you revise one paragraph.
5. Give you a specific assignment for the next session.

By the end, you should understand **what is wrong, why it is wrong, and how to improve it**. That is a much better indicator than the teacher simply sounding intelligent.

Warning signs

Avoid someone who:

- Guarantees that you will earn a 5.
- Focuses almost entirely on vocabulary or grammar worksheets.
- Cannot explain the current AP rubric.
- Gives you a score without explaining the reasoning.
- Talks for the entire lesson while you do little writing.
- Uses only old materials and ignores the digital exam format.
- Teaches one rigid essay template for every prompt.
- Cannot provide a clear plan after reading a sample of your work.

A particularly effective test is to interview **two or three candidates using the same essay**. Choose the person whose feedback is most specific, understandable, and actionable—not necessarily the person with the fanciest credentials.